

US Patent & Trademark Office

Patent Public Search | Text View

United States Patent	12407531
Kind Code	B2
Date of Patent	September 02, 2025
Inventor(s)	Lind; Stephen Woodward et al.

Transparent short-range wireless device factor in a multi-factor authentication system

Abstract

An authentication system supports multi-factor authentication (MFA) when authenticating the identity of a user. A challenge-response portion of the authentication process is delegated to an MFA device-a secondary device within control of the user, but separate from the primary login device that the user is using when initiating the authentication. Communications between the MFA device and the login device are conducted using a short-range wireless communication protocol (e.g., Bluetooth™ or NFC), so that the two devices must be in close physical proximity to each other.

Inventors: Lind; Stephen Woodward (El Cerrito, CA), Sinha; Bidan (Milpitas, CA), Bhat; Karthik (Saratoga, CA), Keerthy; Naveen Kumar (San Jose, CA), He; Jintai (San Mateo, CA), Chandramohan; Kavitha (Maple, CA)

Applicant: OKTA, INC. (San Francisco, CA)

Family ID: 87432715

Appl. No.: 18/424361

Filed: January 26, 2024

Prior Publication Data

Document Identifier	Publication Date
US 20240163117 A1	May. 16, 2024

Related U.S. Application Data

continuation parent-doc US 17589719 20220131 US 11917087 child-doc US 18424361

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: H04L9/32 (20060101); H04W12/0431 (20210101); H04W12/069 (20210101); H04W12/63 (20210101); H04W4/80 (20180101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC H04L9/3273 (20130101); H04W12/0431 (20210101); H04W12/069 (20210101); H04W12/63 (20210101); H04W4/80 (20180201)

Field of Classification Search

CPC: H04L (9/3273); H04L (9/3215); H04L (9/3226); H04L (9/3263); H04L (2209/805); H04L (9/3247); H04L (9/3271); H04W (12/0431); H04W (12/069); H04W (12/63); H04W (4/80); H04W (12/06)

References Cited

U.S. PATENT DOCUMENTS

Patent No.	Issued Date	Patentee Name	U.S. Cl.	CPC
9398012	12/2015	Neuman	N/A	H04L 67/02
11917087	12/2023	Lind et al.	N/A	N/A
2019/0386981	12/2018	Ramesh Kumar	N/A	H04L 9/3228

OTHER PUBLICATIONS

Kensington, “VeriMark(Trademark) Fingerprint Key—FIDO U2F for Universal 2nd Factor Authentication & Windows Hello(Trademark) SKU: K67977WW,” Date Unknown, five pages, [Online] [Retrieved on Oct. 20, 2022] Retrieved from the Internet <URL: <https://www.kensington.com/p/products/data-protection/biometric/verimark-fingerprint-key-fido-u2f-2nd-factor-authentication-and-windows-hello/>>. cited by applicant

Saaspass, “Move Beyond Passwords with The Only Full-Stack Identity & Access Management Solution,” 2021, 23 pages, [Online]] [Retrieved on Oct. 20, 2022] Retrieved from the Internet <URL: <https://saaspass.com/>>. cited by applicant

Symantec, “Symantec VIP—Two Factor Authentication Anywhere,” Date Unknown, six pages, [Online] [Retrieved on Oct. 20, 2022] Retrieved from the Internet <URL: <https://vip.symantec.com/>>. cited by applicant

Wikipedia, “FIDO Alliance,” Jan. 21, 2021, four pages, [Online] [Retrieved on Oct. 20, 2022] Retrieved from the Internet <URL: [https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=FIDO Alliance&oldid=1001844970](https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=FIDO_Alliance&oldid=1001844970)>. cited by applicant

Wikipedia, “Titan Security Key,” Jun. 30, 2022, two pages, [Online] [Retrieved on Oct. 20, 2022] Retrieved from the Internet <URL: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Titan_Security_Key>. cited by applicant

Wikipedia, “YubiKey,” Jan. 14, 2021, eight pages, [Online] [Retrieved on Oct. 20, 2022] Retrieved from the Internet <URL: <https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=YubiKey&oldid=1000388024>>. cited by applicant

Primary Examiner: Okeke; Izunna

Attorney, Agent or Firm: Holland & Hart LLP

Background/Summary

CROSS REFERENCE (1) The present Application for Patent is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 17/589,719 by LIND, et al., entitled “TRANSPARENT SHORT-RANGE WIRELESS DEVICE FACTOR IN A MULTI-FACTOR AUTHENTICATION SYSTEM,” filed Jan. 31, 2022, which is assigned to the assignee hereof and incorporated by reference in its entirety.

FIELD OF ART

(1) The present invention generally relates to the field of software systems, and more particularly, to incorporating a short-range wireless device as an automated factor provider in a multi-factor authentication system.

BACKGROUND

(2) Authentication systems authenticate the purported identity of a user wishing to gain access to a given electronic system. Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) systems enhance security by requiring users to provide multiple different types of credentials (“factors”) before the MFA systems consider the user to be authenticated. For example, an MFA system could require—in addition to a standard credential such as a password—one or more of other types of credentials, such as biometric credentials (e.g., fingerprints), push notifications, one-time passwords received through other channels such as text messaging, or the like.

(3) At the same time that an MFA system should be designed to be highly secure, however, the additional security should not unduly reduce the ease of use of the system. Certain types of credentials are more unwieldy for a user than others. Credential types involving hardware devices (such as smartphones) that are separate from the device that the user is using to access resources (e.g., a laptop) provide strong security by relying on physical possession of a unique piece of hardware (which may additionally be secured by its own credentials). However, typically, when a particular secondary credential involves such a separate device, the user must take express actions to provide secondary credentials for an MFA system via the separate device. For example, push notifications require a user to take out and unlock the user's smartphone device and use it to approve the authentication. Entering a one-time password similarly requires the user to take out and unlock the smartphone device, and additionally to enter the password. Such requirements for user input reduce the seamlessness of the authentication experience and potentially increase user frustration with the system, possibly to the point that the user forgoes the use of a second factor entirely, thereby greatly reducing system security.

SUMMARY

(4) An authentication system supports multi-factor authentication (MFA) when authenticating the identity of a user. A challenge-response portion of the authentication process is delegated to an MFA device—a secondary device within control of the user, but separate from the primary login device that the user is using when initiating the authentication. Communications between the MFA device and the login device are conducted using a short-range wireless communication protocol (e.g., Bluetooth™ or NFC), so that the two devices must be in close physical proximity to each other.

(5) The requirement of close physical proximity of the login device and MFA device enhances the security of the system, since an attacker would need to be very close to the user—and likely within the user's view—to intercept communications between the two devices. The fact that information on the MFA device is communicated directly to the authentication system—rather than relayed through the login device—further enhances security by employing separate communication channels, thereby dramatically increasing the difficulty of attack. The MFA device 121B also participates in the authentication process in a transparent manner, so the user is freed from the need to provide input, which makes the authentication process seamless, as well as secure.

(6) The features and advantages described in the specification are not all inclusive and, in particular, many additional features and advantages will be apparent to one of ordinary skill in the art in view of the drawings, specification, and claims. Moreover, it should be noted that the language used in the specification has been principally selected for readability and instructional purposes, and may not have been selected to delineate or circumscribe the inventive subject matter.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) FIG. 1 illustrates one embodiment of a computing environment in which users use client computing devices to obtain access to authenticated resources over a network, according to some embodiments.
- (2) FIG. 2 illustrates the interactions that take place between the various entities of FIG. 1 during initial enrollment and later runtime authentication, according to some embodiments.
- (3) FIG. 3 is a high-level block diagram illustrating physical components of a computer used as part or all of (for example) the authentication system, the client devices, and/or the resource server of FIG. 1, according to one embodiment.
- (4) The figures depict embodiments of the present invention for purposes of illustration only. One skilled in the art will readily recognize from the following description that alternative embodiments of the structures and methods illustrated herein may be employed without departing from the principles of the invention described herein.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(5) FIG. 1 illustrates one embodiment of a computing environment in which users use client computing devices to obtain access to authenticated resources over a network, according to some embodiments. The users are affiliated with an organization (e.g., employees or volunteers of the organization) and may access the resources on behalf of the organization. The users may have multiple accounts on different systems, and the resources that the users access may be owned and/or administered by different independent entities, such that the users may have a number of different identities—and corresponding credentials—across the different systems. The different accounts may provide the users with access to different resources, such as (for example) applications (e.g., email applications, timekeeping applications, spreadsheet applications, etc.), databases, file systems, or the like. Such applications could be, for example, entirely web-based and accessible through a web browser, or could be accessible through a native application installed on the user's client device and communicating with a remote application server. Since each application or other resource could be from a different provider—each of which could have a different identity for a user—a single user will typically have many different identities and associated credentials corresponding to the different resources that the user uses. However, for purposes of the invention, a user need only have a single account with a single corresponding identity.

(6) An authentication system verifies the identities of users, ensuring that the user to be authenticated is indeed the specific user that the user is claiming to be (the “purported user”). If the user is successfully verified, the authentication system provides an authentication token that a resource server will accept as proof of the user's identity (e.g., via an OAuth flow) and hence of the user's permission to access requested resources. The authentication system offers multi-factor authentication (MFA), such as one-time passwords (OTP), biometrics, or the like, in addition to a primary credential (e.g., a password). The entities of FIG. 1 are now described in more detail.

(7) The organization **120** is an entity, such as a business, a school, a governmental agency, or the like, that has a number of affiliated users **129**, such as employees or volunteers. One or more client devices **121** (such as login device **121A** and MFA device **121B**) are registered to the users **129** by

the organization **120** (or, in some embodiments, inferred from observation of past successful login patterns), and the users use the client devices to access resources associated with the organization. Although for simplicity FIG. 1 illustrates only a single user **129**, login device **121A**, and MFA device **121B**, there may be any number of either. Any given user **129** may have an MFA device **121B**, which acts in conjunction with the login device **121A** to provide additional security via automated short-range wireless MFA.

(8) The resource server **130** provides access a resource, such as a web-based application (e.g., MICROSOFT OFFICE 365™), a service, a database, a document, or the like. The resource server **130** may be on a server separate from the systems of the authentication system **100** or the organization **120**, or it may be part of any of the other systems. The resource server **130** requires authentication of users before the users may gain access to some or all of its resources, and (in embodiments in which the resource server **130** is independent of the authentication system **100**) the resource server **130** accepts tokens of authentication from the authentication system **100** as establishing user identity.

(9) The authentication system **100** authenticates the identity of the user **129**, granting the user some proof of authentication, such as an authentication token, upon successful verification. The authentication system **100** stores user data **101** that include a set of identities of known users with accounts on the authentication system **100**. (In FIG. 1, the block for “organization **120**” within the authentication system **100** symbolizes that the organization **120** has a set of data on the authentication system that is dedicated to the organization, such as the user data **101** corresponding to that organization.) The user data **101** may include a form of identity on the authentication system **100** such as a username, as well as other credential data associated with a user, such as a user password and/or information derived therefrom (such as an encrypted form of the password). The user data **101** may also include many other types of data about users, such as the credential types and providers that the users may use when seeking identity verification from the authentication system **100**, their role(s) or group(s) within the organization **120** to which they belong (e.g., “Engineering”, “Legal”, “Manager 2”, “Director”, or the like), and/or the resources to which they have access (e.g., third-party applications such as SALESFORCE, MICROSOFT OFFICE 365, SLACK, or the like), as some examples. The user data **101** may also include identities and credentials of the various users on the various accounts to which they have access, thereby linking a user's identity on the authentication system **100** to the user's identities on those different accounts and (by extension) permitting access to those accounts. In some embodiments, the authentication system **100** is part of the organization **120**, rather than being an independent entity as it is in other embodiments. In some embodiments, the authentication system **100** is a multi-tenant system, supporting multiple organizations **120** that serve as tenants of the system. In such embodiments, there is one instance of each of the organization-specific components (e.g., the user data **101**) for each tenant organization.

(10) In some embodiments, software on the client device(s) **121** facilitates user authentication by securely and transparently communicating with the authentication system **100** that primarily handles the authentication, and by providing any resulting authentication tokens to a resource server **130** whose resources the user is attempting to access. In this way, the users of the organization **120** simply and securely obtain access to the resources that they need. Such software on the client device(s) **121** may (although need not) be provided by the entity responsible for the authentication system **100**. In some embodiments, the software is an authenticator application, a locally-installed application. In such embodiments, the authenticator application may have a graphical user interface that the user **129** uses to specify data used to authenticate the user to the authentication system **100**. For instance, the authenticator application could display text fields or other data entry areas for specifying a username and password of the user **129**, a drop-down list or other menu of types of MFA factors to use for authentication (e.g., biometrics such as voice verification, physical tokens, push notifications, or OTP), or the like. Based on the data and/or

selections specified by the user **129** in the user interface, the authenticator application communicates with the authentication system **100** to authenticate the user on the authentication system **100**. In other embodiments, the authenticator application is implemented as a plugin for another application. In embodiments described below, in which the MFA device **121B** is used to provide transparent authentication, there is no need for a user interface for user input for some or all of the authentication process.

(11) Physically, the organization **120** is made up of a number of computing systems, including the various client devices **121**; one or more internal networks that connects the computing systems, including routers or other networking devices that define the boundary between the organization and external networks; and the like.

(12) Similarly, the authentication system **100**, although depicted as a single logical system in FIG. **1**, may be implemented using a number of distinct physical systems and the connections between them, such as application servers, database servers, load-balancing servers, routers, and the like.

(13) The network **140** may be any suitable communications network for data transmission. In an embodiment such as that illustrated in FIG. **1**, the network **140** uses standard communications technologies and/or protocols and can include the Internet. In another embodiment, the entities use custom and/or dedicated data communications technologies.

(14) In some embodiments, the authentication system **100** includes single sign-on (SSO) functionality that once the user has been authenticated allows the authentication system to transparently log a user in to the different accounts or other resources to which the user has access. For example, for a given user who has logged in to the authentication system **100**, the authentication system can look up the user's accounts or other resources within the user data **101**, as well as the user's credentials for those accounts. Using the credentials, as well as metadata or other information about the accounts, authentication system **100** can automatically log the user into the applications or other resources described in the user data **101**, such as by establishing application sessions with the various applications and providing corresponding session data (e.g., session tokens) to the device **121**. Thus, with a single login to the authentication system **100**, the SSO functionality of the authentication system provides a user with automatic access to all the user's accounts or other resources.

(15) The authentication system **100** has an authenticator module **102** that (in concert with other modules on other systems) handles the details of authenticating that a particular authentication request does indeed originate from or on behalf of the purported user. In some embodiments, the authenticator module **102** supports multi-factor authentication (MFA), requiring that users using MFA provide not only a primary credential type (e.g., password), but also one or more secondary credential types. When a particular user requests authentication of the user's identity, the authenticator module **102** looks up the user in the user data **101** according to the user's purported identity (e.g., username), noting the credential types that the user is eligible to use for MFA. For example, if the purported user has previously been enrolled to use challenges conveyed over short-range wireless as a credential type (and an administrator has not disallowed its use), the authenticator module allows this to be used as a verification option for the user during authentication.

(16) The login device **121A**, MFA device **121B**, and authenticator **102** have a number of components that interoperate to provide authentication using short-range wireless communication. These components are now described.

(17) The login device **121A** and the MFA device **121B** both have a short-range wireless component, which includes the hardware and software (firmware, drivers, etc.) needed to communicate using a particular type of short-range wireless. As some non-exhaustive examples, in some embodiments the short-range wireless uses Bluetooth™, and in other embodiments, the short-range wireless uses near-field communication (NFC). In some embodiments, the short-range wireless component has a maximum range of no more than 100 meters. The fact that the type of wireless technology being

used has a short range enhances the security of the system, since it restricts the MFA device **121B** from being used beyond a short distance from the login device **121A**, since it must remain within the signal range of that wireless type. This tight proximity requirement makes it dramatically more difficult for an attacker to gain access to or tamper with the communications, since the attacker would need to be physically nearby to—and likely visible to—the true user. Since virtually all (e.g., more than 99%) of security attacks are performed from locations far away from the user in question, the tight proximity requirement eliminates virtually all such attacks.

(18) The login device **121A** has an application **128** with a user interface that the user **129** uses to interact—directly or indirectly—with the authentication system **100**. For example, the application **128** can be a web browser in which the authentication system **100** provides an HTML and JavaScript-based user interface for the user to access the user's various applications managed through the authentication system. Alternatively, the application **128** can be a native application specially designed to interact with the authentication system **100**. Similarly, the MFA device **121B** may have a security application **122** that manages interactions with the login device **121A** and with the authentication system **100** when performing authentication operations, such as the operations illustrated in FIG. 2, discussed below.

(19) The MFA device **121B** and authenticator **102** additionally have cryptographic modules **124**, **104** that perform the asymmetric key cryptographic operations that are used during authentication, such as encryption, decryption, signing, and signature verification.

(20) The MFA device **121B** additionally includes a metadata collection module **125** that obtains metadata to be provided to the authentication system **100** to further increase the level of security during authentication. The collected metadata describes characteristics of the MFA device **121B** and/or the user **129** (for example), and analysis of this metadata allows the authentication system **100** to further verify that the user **129** requesting authentication is indeed the purported user. More details on the collected metadata are provided below in connection with step **250** of FIG. 2.

(21) FIG. 2 illustrates the interactions that take place between the various entities of FIG. 1 during initial enrollment and later runtime authentication, according to some embodiments. In order to be part of authentication, the MFA device **121B** of a user is first enrolled with the authentication system **100**. After enrollment, the MFA device **121B** operates together with the user's login device **121A** to semi-transparently or fully-transparently authenticate the user with the authentication system **100**. These phases are now described in additional detail.

(22) Enrollment Phase

(23) The MFA device **121B** is first enrolled **205** with the authentication system **100**. For example, the user of the MFA device **121B** may use a graphical user interface of security application **122** to begin the enrollment process. As part of enrollment **205**, the MFA device **121B** (e.g., using its cryptographic module **124** and security application **122**) generates a <public, private> keypair from a secure asymmetric key cryptosystem, such as a discrete log or elliptic curve cryptosystem. The MFA device **121B** securely stores the private key and registers the public key with the authentication system **100** to enable future secure communications, including the ability to verify cryptographic signatures. The registration may also include other identifying information associated with the MFA device **121B** that the authentication system **100** can later use to verify the MFA device, such as a unique identifier for the device itself, operating system version/subversion of the MFA device, an identifier (e.g., a username) used to uniquely identify the user **129** to the authentication system **100**, and/or the like. This information may be saved in the user data **101** in association with the user **129**.

(24) The MFA device **121B** may optionally also pair **210** with the login device **121A** in order to gain the ability to establish secure (encrypted) communication channels when communicating with the login device **121A** using the short-range wireless connection **126**. The pairing **210** need only be done once. Future secure communications may exchange different types of information—such as a shared secret, personal identification number (PIN), or asymmetric keys, in different embodiments

—to establish a secure (encrypted) communication channel over the short-range wireless connection **126**.

(25) Authentication Phase

(26) The authentication flow of FIG. 2 begins when there is a request **225** via the login device **121A** for a resource of the resource server **130** or of another system that requires authentication by the authentication system **100** before permitting access. For example, the user **129** might generate the request **225** by clicking on a link or icon for an application within a dashboard user interface provided by the application **128** and showing all of the user's applications managed by the authentication system. This causes the browser (or other application presenting the user interface to the user) to send a message leading to acquiring **230** challenge metadata. The message may be an express request for authentication (if the application **128** knows that the user **129** is not currently logged in to the authentication system **100**), or a request for the resource desired by the user (in which case the authentication system **100** is the one to determine that the user is not logged in to the authentication system).

(27) In any case, the authentication system **100** accordingly obtains and provides **231** the challenge metadata. The challenge metadata is a mechanism for the authentication system **100** to prove its authenticity to a user's device using a public key and signature, as well as a nonce value for the user's device to sign using its own private MFA key (where the paired public key was previously registered with the authentication system during the enrollment phase), thereby establishing the user's identity to the authentication system via its possession of the private key from the enrollment phase.

(28) Rather than the login device **121A** handling the response to the challenge of the authentication system **100**, the login device **121A** instead delegates the response to the MFA device **121B** by sending **235** the challenge metadata to the MFA device **121B** over the short-range wireless connection **126**. This delegation has the benefit of allowing the MFA device **121B** to provide a transparent response, thereby sparing the user **129** the need to be involved in the response. It has the further benefit of increasing security by communicating with the authentication system **100** through a different channel than that through which the original communication **230** came, which makes it more difficult for attackers to tamper with the communications between the client devices **121** and the authentication system **100**.

(29) Upon receipt of the challenge metadata from the login device **121A**, the MFA device **121B** replies to the authentication system challenge, additionally providing further metadata to enhance security. More specifically, in some embodiments the MFA device **121B** ensures the integrity of the challenge by verifying **240** the signature of the authentication system **100** on the challenge metadata, e.g., by using the known public key of the authentication system **100**. The MFA device also determines **245** an answer to the challenge provided **231** by the authentication system **100**. For example, if the challenge was a nonce value encrypted by the authentication system **100** using the public key of the MFA device **121B** that was generated and provided during enrollment, then the MFA device decrypts the nonce value using its private key that had been generated during enrollment **205**.

(30) The MFA device **121B** (e.g., via the metadata collection module **125**) also generates **250** MFA metadata to be provided to the authentication system **100** to further increase the level of security. The MFA metadata includes characteristics of the MFA device **121B** and/or the user **129**, which the authentication system can use to further increase confidence in the authenticity of the resource request **225**. For example, in some embodiments the MFA metadata includes proximity information indicating a physical distance of the MFA device **121B** from the login device **121A**. The distance is relevant because if the distance is sufficiently small (e.g., within a few feet) then presumably the same user is using both devices, whereas if the devices were far apart one of the two devices might be being operated by another user not in view of the true user, such as in the street outside a home. The distance may be computed based on, for example, the signal strength of the short-range

wireless when received from the login device **121A** by the MFA device **121B**. The MFA metadata can include other values, such as a geolocation of the MFA device **121B**, device ID of the MFA device, operating system version and subversion of the MFA device, and the like. This information can be matched against the metadata supplied in the enrollment of step **205**. Beyond any proximity information included within the MFA metadata, the MFA metadata inherently establishes that the MFA device **121A** shares a physical presence with the login device **121A**, in that since the two devices are communicating **235** over the short-range wireless connection **126**, they must be within at most the maximum range of the short-range wireless connection.

(31) The MFA device **121B** can also sign **255** the payload (which includes the challenge answer and the MFA metadata, and possibly other values, such as any additional values provided by the login device **121A** in step **235**, such as an identifier (e.g., username) of the user **129** on the authentication system) using its private key generated during enrollment **205**.

(32) The MFA device **121B** sends **260** the resulting payload to the authentication system **100**. The payload is sent directly to the authentication system **100**, in that it is not relayed through the login device **121A** (although of course it is still typically relayed through intermediary routers and other network devices before arriving at the authentication system **100**). Upon receipt of the payload from the MFA device **121B**, the authentication system **100** verifies **265** that the provided answer to its challenge is correct (e.g., that the answer matches the original nonce value). The authentication system **100** may also determine **270** a next action for the authentication process based on additional considerations such as the strength of the MFA metadata, a match of the MFA metadata data provided in the payload to metadata provided by the MFA device **121B** in the enrollment step **205**, security settings of the user **129**, policies of an organization **120** of which the user **129** is a member, or the like. For example, a policy of the organization might specify that as long as the challenge is answered correctly and the operating system version in the MFA metadata matches that originally provided during enrollment **205**, the user **129** should be immediately authenticated, in which case the next action could be to authenticate the user and provide a corresponding authentication token. Alternatively, the policy might specify that in addition to the challenge being correctly answered, the user **129** must also provide the user's password as long as the proximity information indicates a distance over 5 feet between the login device **121A** and the MFA device **121B**, as just one example. In this example, if the distance were over 5 feet, then the next action would be to request a password from the user **129**. The authentication system takes the determined next action **275**, such as issuing an authentication token for access to a resource, updating a web page of the user to request a password, or the like.

(33) The process of FIG. 2 takes place transparently, in that steps **230-275** are performed without manual input from the user, given that the MFA device **121B**, in concert with the login device **121A** and the authentication system **100**, automatically performs the necessary actions. Thus, to accomplish this portion of the authentication, the user **129** need only have the MFA device **121B** nearby, and need not enter any data into it or even unlock it. Of course, depending on the particular authentication policy, the user **129** may be required to perform additional manual steps (such as entering a password), but such steps are tangential to the authentication of steps **230-275**.

(34) As noted, if the pairing **210** is performed, then communications between the login device **121A** and the MFA device **121B** may be further secured (encrypted). In this way, even if an attacker manages to come within the range of the short-range wireless connection **126**, the sending **235** of the challenge metadata can still be secured against tampering by the attacker due to the encryption of the connection.

(35) Note that although the interactions of FIG. 2 were described as occurring in a particular order, variations are possible in different embodiments. As just one example, the actions **240, 245**, and **250** are independent of each other and hence could be done any order, or in parallel.

(36) FIG. 3 is a high-level block diagram illustrating physical components of a computer **300** used as part or all of (for example) the authentication system **100**, the client devices **121**, and/or the

resource server **130** of FIG. **1**, according to one embodiment. Illustrated are at least one processor **302** coupled to a chipset **304**. Also coupled to the chipset **304** are a memory **306**, a storage device **308**, a graphics adapter **312**, and a network adapter **316**. A display **318** is coupled to the graphics adapter **312**. In one embodiment, the functionality of the chipset **304** is provided by a memory controller hub **320** and an I/O controller hub **322**. In another embodiment, the memory **306** is coupled directly to the processor **302** instead of the chipset **304**.

(37) The storage device **308** is any non-transitory computer-readable storage medium, such as a hard drive, compact disk read-only memory (CD-ROM), DVD, or a solid-state memory device. The memory **306** holds instructions and data used by the processor **302**. The graphics adapter **312** displays images and other information on the display **318**. The network adapter **316** couples the computer **300** to a local or wide area network.

(38) As is known in the art, a computer **300** can have different and/or other components than those shown in FIG. **3**. In addition, the computer **300** can lack certain illustrated components. In one embodiment, a computer **300** acting as a server may lack a graphics adapter **312**, and/or display **318**, as well as a keyboard **310** or pointing device **314**. Moreover, the storage device **308** can be local and/or remote from the computer **300** (such as embodied within a storage area network (SAN)).

(39) As is known in the art, the computer **300** is adapted to execute computer program modules for providing functionality described herein. As used herein, the term “module” refers to computer program logic utilized to provide the specified functionality. Thus, a module can be implemented in hardware, firmware, and/or software. In one embodiment, program modules are stored on the storage device **308**, loaded into the memory **306**, and executed by the processor **302**.

(40) Embodiments of the entities described herein can include other and/or different modules than the ones described here. In addition, the functionality attributed to the modules can be performed by other or different modules in other embodiments. Moreover, this description occasionally omits the term “module” for purposes of clarity and convenience.

OTHER CONSIDERATIONS

(41) The present invention has been described in particular detail with respect to one possible embodiment. Those of skill in the art will appreciate that the invention may be practiced in other embodiments. First, the particular naming of the components and variables, capitalization of terms, the attributes, data structures, or any other programming or structural aspect is not mandatory or significant, and the mechanisms that implement the invention or its features may have different names, formats, or protocols. Also, the particular division of functionality between the various system components described herein is merely for purposes of example, and is not mandatory; functions performed by a single system component may instead be performed by multiple components, and functions performed by multiple components may instead performed by a single component.

(42) Some portions of above description present the features of the present invention in terms of algorithms and symbolic representations of operations on information. These algorithmic descriptions and representations are the means used by those skilled in the data processing arts to most effectively convey the substance of their work to others skilled in the art. These operations, while described functionally or logically, are understood to be implemented by computer programs. Furthermore, it has also proven convenient at times, to refer to these arrangements of operations as modules or by functional names, without loss of generality.

(43) Unless specifically stated otherwise as apparent from the above discussion, it is appreciated that throughout the description, discussions utilizing terms such as “determining” or “displaying” or the like, refer to the action and processes of a computer system, or similar electronic computing device, that manipulates and transforms data represented as physical (electronic) quantities within the computer system memories or registers or other such information storage, transmission or display devices.

(44) Certain aspects of the present invention include process steps and instructions described herein in the form of an algorithm. It should be noted that the process steps and instructions of the present invention could be embodied in software, firmware or hardware, and when embodied in software, could be downloaded to reside on and be operated from different platforms used by real time network operating systems.

(45) The present invention also relates to an apparatus for performing the operations herein. This apparatus may be specially constructed for the required purposes, or it may comprise a general-purpose computer selectively activated or reconfigured by a computer program stored on a computer readable medium that can be accessed by the computer. Such a computer program may be stored in a non-transitory computer readable storage medium, such as, but is not limited to, any type of disk including floppy disks, optical disks, CD-ROMs, magnetic-optical disks, read-only memories (ROMs), random access memories (RAMs), EPROMs, EEPROMs, magnetic or optical cards, application specific integrated circuits (ASICs), or any type of computer-readable storage medium suitable for storing electronic instructions, and each coupled to a computer system bus. Furthermore, the computers referred to in the specification may include a single processor or may be architectures employing multiple processor designs for increased computing capability.

(46) The algorithms and operations presented herein are not inherently related to any particular computer or other apparatus. Various general-purpose systems may also be used with programs in accordance with the teachings herein, or it may prove convenient to construct more specialized apparatus to perform the required method steps. The required structure for a variety of these systems will be apparent to those of skill in the art, along with equivalent variations. In addition, the present invention is not described with reference to any particular programming language. It is appreciated that a variety of programming languages may be used to implement the teachings of the present invention as described herein, and any references to specific languages are provided for invention of enablement and best mode of the present invention.

(47) The present invention is well suited to a wide variety of computer network systems over numerous topologies. Within this field, the configuration and management of large networks comprise storage devices and computers that are communicatively coupled to dissimilar computers and storage devices over a network, such as the Internet.

(48) Finally, it should be noted that the language used in the specification has been principally selected for readability and instructional purposes, and may not have been selected to delineate or circumscribe the inventive subject matter. Accordingly, the disclosure of the present invention is intended to be illustrative, but not limiting, of the scope of the invention, which is set forth in the claims.

Claims

1. A computer-implemented method for secure, automated multi-factor authentication (MFA) login to a resource performed by an MFA device, the computer-implemented method comprising: enrolling with an authentication system, the enrolling comprising: pairing with a login device to establish data for an encrypted communication channel between the MFA device and the login device over a short-range wireless connection; providing, to the authentication system, a public key of the MFA device and metadata describing the MFA device; receiving, over the short-range wireless connection, authentication challenge metadata sent to the login device by the authentication system in response to a request by the login device to access a resource for which authentication is required; generating MFA metadata to establish that the MFA device shares a physical presence with the login device; and sending the MFA metadata to the authentication system, wherein responsive to verifying the MFA metadata using the metadata provided to the authentication system during the enrolling, the authentication system authenticates the login device.
2. The computer-implemented method of claim 1, wherein the metadata describing the MFA device

comprises at least one of: an operating system ID of the MFA device, or network information of the MFA device.

3. The computer-implemented method of claim 1, wherein the short-range wireless connection comprises a BLUETOOTH connection or a near-field communication (NFC) connection.
4. The computer-implemented method of claim 1, further comprising: verifying a signature of the authentication system on the authentication challenge metadata.
5. The computer-implemented method of claim 1, further comprising: determining an answer to a challenge of the authentication challenge metadata by decrypting a nonce value using a private key corresponding to the public key of the MFA device.
6. The computer-implemented method of claim 5, wherein the authentication system authenticates the login device, wherein the authentication comprises verifying at least one of: the answer to the challenge, or the MFA metadata using the metadata describing the MFA device.
7. The computer-implemented method of claim 1, wherein the MFA metadata comprises an indicator of a physical distance of the MFA device from the login device.
8. The computer-implemented method of claim 7, wherein the indicator of the physical distance is computed based on a signal strength of the short-range wireless connection when received from the login device the MFA device.
9. The computer-implemented method of claim 1, wherein the receiving, the generating, and the sending are performed by the MFA device without manual input from a user.
10. A computer-implemented method for secure, automated multi-factor authentication (MFA) login to a resource performed by an authentication system, the computer-implemented method comprising: enrolling an MFA device, the enrolling comprising: pairing the MFA device with a login device to establish data for an encrypted communication channel between the MFA device and the login device over a short-range wireless connection; obtaining, from the MFA device, a public key of the MFA device, and metadata describing the MFA device; receiving, on behalf of a user from the login device, a request for authentication; sending, over the short-range wireless connection, authentication challenge metadata to the login device; receiving, from the MFA device, MFA metadata in response to sending the authentication challenge metadata to the login device; verifying, using the received MFA metadata, that the MFA device is within a threshold distance of the login device; and issuing an authentication token for the login device.
11. The computer-implemented method of claim 10, wherein the authentication challenge metadata further comprises a nonce value generated by the authentication system and encrypted using the public key of the MFA device.
12. The computer-implemented method of claim 10, wherein the MFA metadata comprises an indicator of a physical distance of the MFA device from the login device.
13. The computer-implemented method of claim 12, wherein the indicator of the physical distance is computed based on a signal strength of the short-range wireless connection when received from the login device the MFA device.
14. A multi-factor authentication (MFA) device comprising at least one memory that stores code and one or more processors coupled with the at least one memory, wherein the one or more processors are operable to execute the code to cause the MFA device to login to a resource, the login comprising: enrolling with an authentication system, the enrolling comprising: pairing with a login device to establish data for an encrypted communication channel between the MFA device and the login device over a short-range wireless connection; providing, to the authentication system, a public key of the MFA device and metadata describing the MFA device; receiving, over the short-range wireless connection, authentication challenge metadata sent to the login device by the authentication system in response to a request by the login device to access a resource for which authentication is required; generating MFA metadata to establish that the MFA device shares a physical presence with the login device; and sending the MFA metadata to the authentication system, wherein responsive to verifying the MFA metadata using the metadata provided to the

authentication system during the enrolling, the authentication system authenticates the login device.

15. The MFA device of claim 14, wherein the metadata describing the MFA device comprises at least one of: an operating system ID of the MFA device, or network information of the MFA device.

16. The MFA device of claim 14, wherein the short-range wireless connection comprises a BLUETOOTH connection or a near-field communication (NFC) connection.

17. The MFA device of claim 14, wherein the MFA metadata comprises an indicator of a physical distance of the MFA device from the login device.

18. The MFA device of claim 17, wherein the indicator of the physical distance is computed based on a signal strength of the short-range wireless connection when received from the login device the MFA device.

19. The MFA device of claim 14, wherein the authentication system authenticates the login device, wherein the authentication comprises verifying at least one of: an answer to a challenge of the authentication challenge metadata, or the MFA metadata using the metadata describing the MFA device.
